OUTDOOR LIVING TRENDS 2026

10 Macro Shifts Defining Outdoor Living
For Architects, Builders, and Homeowners



BROMIC® HEATING

THE SHIFT IN NUMBERS

Outdoor living has shifted from a seasonal luxury to a fundamental part of modern homes, driven by more time spent at home, the rise of hybrid work lifestyles, increased investment in residential renovations, and a growing emphasis on seamless indoor-outdoor design.

According to the *American Institute of Architects Home Design Trends Survey*, outdoor spaces remain among the most requested features in new homes, and integrated indoor-outdoor layouts continue to rise in popularity, reflecting a broader move toward homes that support both lifestyle and functionality.

Explore how homeowners and trade professionals are transforming outdoor areas into essential extensions of the home.

61.8%

of new single-family homes include patios

NAHB Home Design Trends Survey, 2024

55%

of architects report increased demand for outdoor living spaces

American Institute of Architects (AIA), 2025

$522B

projected annual U.S. home improvement spending by 2026

Harvard Joint Center for Housing Studies, 2025

33%

of homeowners upgrade outdoor areas to expand their living space

Houzz Renovation Trends Study

Outdoor spaces are no longer seasonal—they're expected to function year-round.

01

OUTDOOR LIVING IS THE NEW HEART OF THE HOME

Gather Dine Work Relax

Outdoor living spaces are increasingly the social heart of the home, with covered patios, terraces, and outdoor lounges serving as venues for family gatherings, entertaining, relaxation, wellness activities, and even casual work or study.

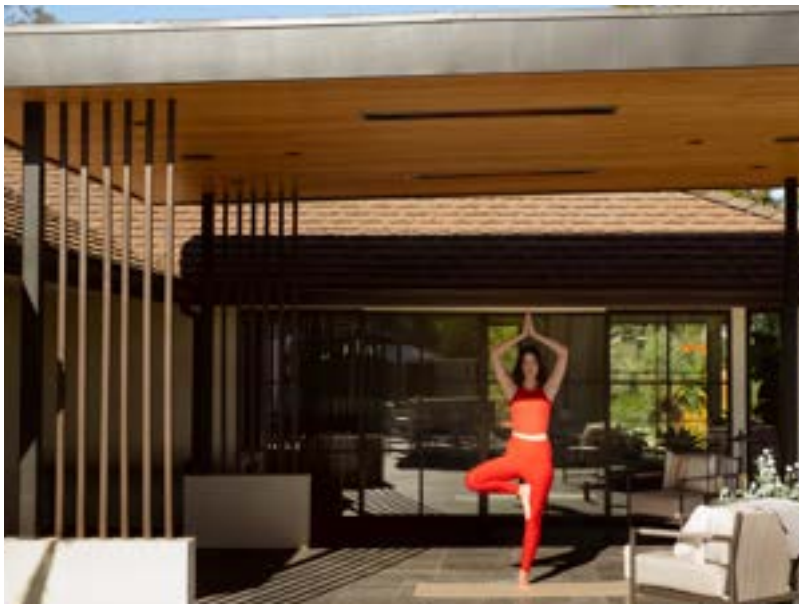
Reflecting this shift, architect surveys consistently rank outdoor living areas among the top design priorities in new homes, highlighting their growing importance in contemporary residential design.
AIA Home Design Trends Survey

- Social spaces are moving outdoors
- Patios now support dining, work, and relaxation
- Outdoor areas are designed as home extensions

67% say heating extends outdoor use
US Homeowner Survey, Atomik Research

BROMIC INSIGHT
Design-led radiant heat enables outdoor spaces to function as true extensions of the indoors, enabling usage beyond daylight hours.









02

OUTDOOR USAGE THROUGHOUT THE DAY

Morning | Afternoon | Evening

Outdoor spaces are evolving into versatile, multi-use environments that support activities throughout the day.

Mornings are often reserved for coffee, yoga, or quiet reading, while afternoons may include working outdoors, children playing, or casual meals. Evenings are increasingly devoted to cooking, entertaining, and lounging.

That said, many face restrictions on outdoor use during the cooler hours of the morning and evening and throughout the colder seasons.

94% of homeowners say their outdoor space could be used more

23% less than 1 in 4 homeowners prioritize outdoor heating during the planning phase

US Homeowner Survey, Atomik Research

BROMIC INSIGHT

Radiant heating extends the hours outdoor spaces remain comfortable, allowing homeowners to extend the moment.

03

PATIOS = CORE RESIDENTIAL INFRASTRUCTURE

Built-In **Designed** **Essential**

Patios have moved beyond decorative landscape features to become essential components of modern homes, serving as functional living spaces for daily life and entertaining.

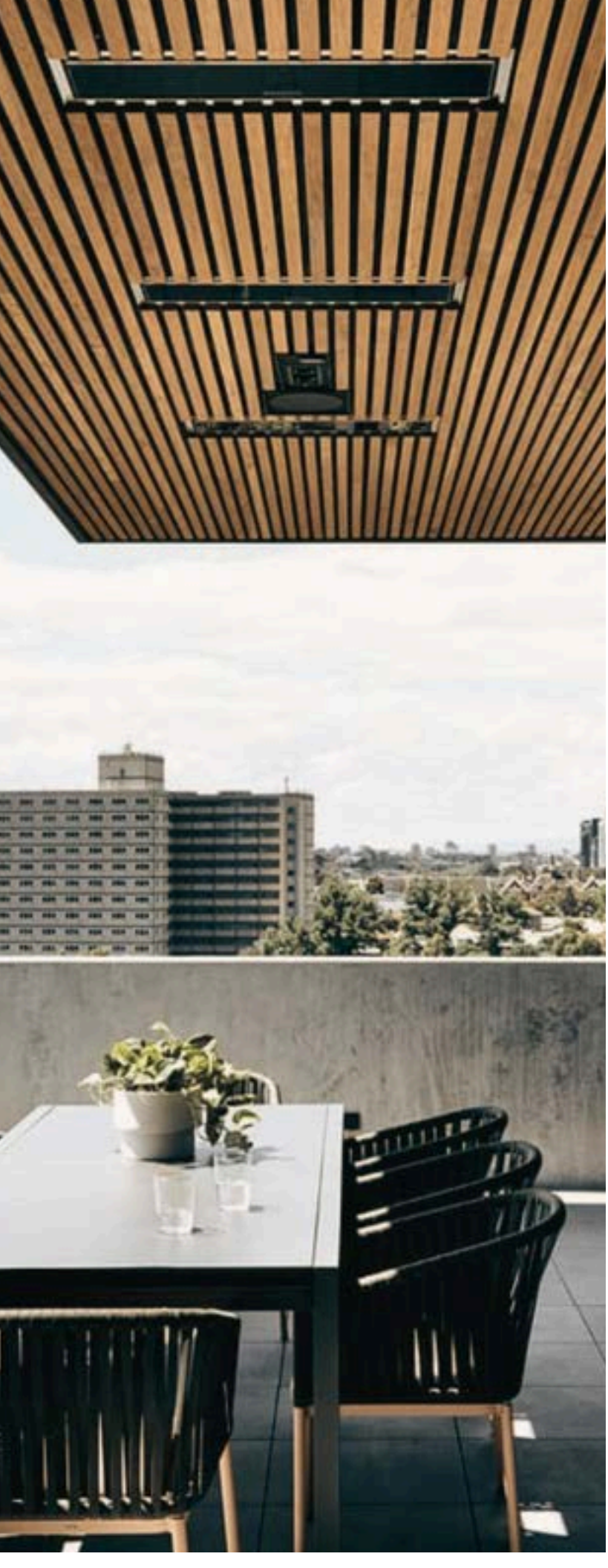
According to the *NAHB Builder Practices Survey*, **61.8%** of new homes now include patios, with the average new-home patio measuring around 320 square feet.

New patios also deliver strong value, achieving **95%** cost recovery and earning homeowners a satisfaction score of 9.9, highlighting their appeal as both practical and desirable additions.
National Association of Realtors Remodeling Impact Report

- Patios are no longer decorative—they are functional living spaces
- Outdoor areas are designed into the home—not added later
- Layout, structure, and integrated systems are planned together

BROMIC INSIGHT
Heating transforms patios from occasional spaces into regularly used, everyday living environments.





04

OUTDOOR RENOVATION SPENDING REMAINS STRONG

Renovate **Invest** **Value**

Outdoor renovation continues to be a significant focus of residential improvement spending, driven by several key factors.

Aging housing stock, a preference among homeowners to improve rather than move, and a desire for lifestyle upgrades centered.

The outdoor experience is all fueling investment in outdoor spaces, making them an increasingly important element of home design and value.

Upgrades to outdoor living not only enhance daily life but also increase a home's resale value.

- Homeowners are investing more in outdoor living upgrades
- Renovation is prioritized over moving
- Outdoor spaces are a key focus for lifestyle improvements

$522B

projected annual home improvement spend
Harvard Joint Center for Housing Sturdies - LIRA

BROMIC INSIGHT
Heating is a relatively small addition that significantly increases how often outdoor spaces are regularly used.

05

THE BOUNDARY BETWEEN INDOOR AND OUTDOOR HAS DISAPPEARED

Open Plan **Seamless Flow** **Connected Spaces**

Homes are increasingly designed to create a seamless indoor-outdoor flow, blurring the boundaries between interior and exterior spaces.

Key architectural elements that enable this integration include retractable glass walls, covered terraces, integrated outdoor kitchens, and continuous flooring materials, all of which contribute to a cohesive, functional, and visually connected living environment.

- Indoor and outdoor spaces are designed as one continuous environment
- Architectural elements extend seamlessly beyond the interior
- Outdoor areas are planned as part of the overall living layout

40% of architects report increased demand for indoor-outdoor living

AIA Home Design Trends Survey

BROMIC INSIGHT

Recessed and design-led heating solutions preserve clean architectural lines while maintaining maximum warmth.





06

PERGOLAS AND STRUCTURES ARE DEFINING OUTDOOR SPACES

Structure **Shelter** **Integration**

Pergolas and other outdoor structures are becoming essential design anchors for modern outdoor living, shaping spaces that are as functional as they are inviting.

Beyond providing shade and shelter, they define areas for gathering, seamlessly integrate lighting, audio, and heating, and transform patios and terraces into comfortable, year-round extensions of the home.

- Pergolas define zones for gathering and activity
- Structures are designed as part of the home—not added later
- They enable integration of lighting, audio, and heating systems

BROMIC INSIGHT

Pergolas provide ideal mounting surfaces for integrated radient heating systems providing flexibility for homeowners and trade professionals.

07

SMART OUTDOOR LIVING IS THE NEW STANDARD

Control Lighting Connection

Smart outdoor living is no longer emerging—it's an expectation for homeowners who require their exterior spaces to function as seamlessly as their indoor environments.

From lighting control and automated pergolas, to integrated audio and heating systems, outdoor spaces are becoming fully connected and responsive, capable of adapting to any activity or time of day.

Today's patios, terraces, and gardens are no longer optional amenities—they are anticipated extensions of a smart, modern home.

- Outdoor spaces are increasingly integrated with smart home systems
- Homeowners expect control over lighting, heating, and audio from one platform
- Demand for seamless, app-based control is rapidly growing

BROMIC INSIGHT
Integrated heating systems connect seamlessly with smart home platforms—allowing users to control heat, lighting, and comfort from a single interface.





08

DESIGN-LED OUTDOOR PRODUCTS ARE REPLACING UTILITY PRODUCTS

Design **Aesthetic** **Architecture**

Outdoor products are increasingly evaluated not just for function, but for their architectural aesthetics, reflecting a broader trend toward minimalism.

Homeowners and designers are embracing recessed lighting, hidden speakers, flush-mounted heaters, and streamlined furniture to create outdoor spaces that feel elegant, uncluttered, and seamlessly integrated with the home's overall design.

- Outdoor products are selected for both performance and architectural integration
- Clean, minimal design is replacing visible or standalone elements
- Spaces are designed to feel cohesive with the home's overall aesthetic

BROMIC INSIGHT
Smart heating controls allow seamless intgration into modern home automation ecosystems.

09

MAXIMUM DESIGN IMPACT IN COMPACT SPACES

Zoning **Mulit-Use** **Efficiency**

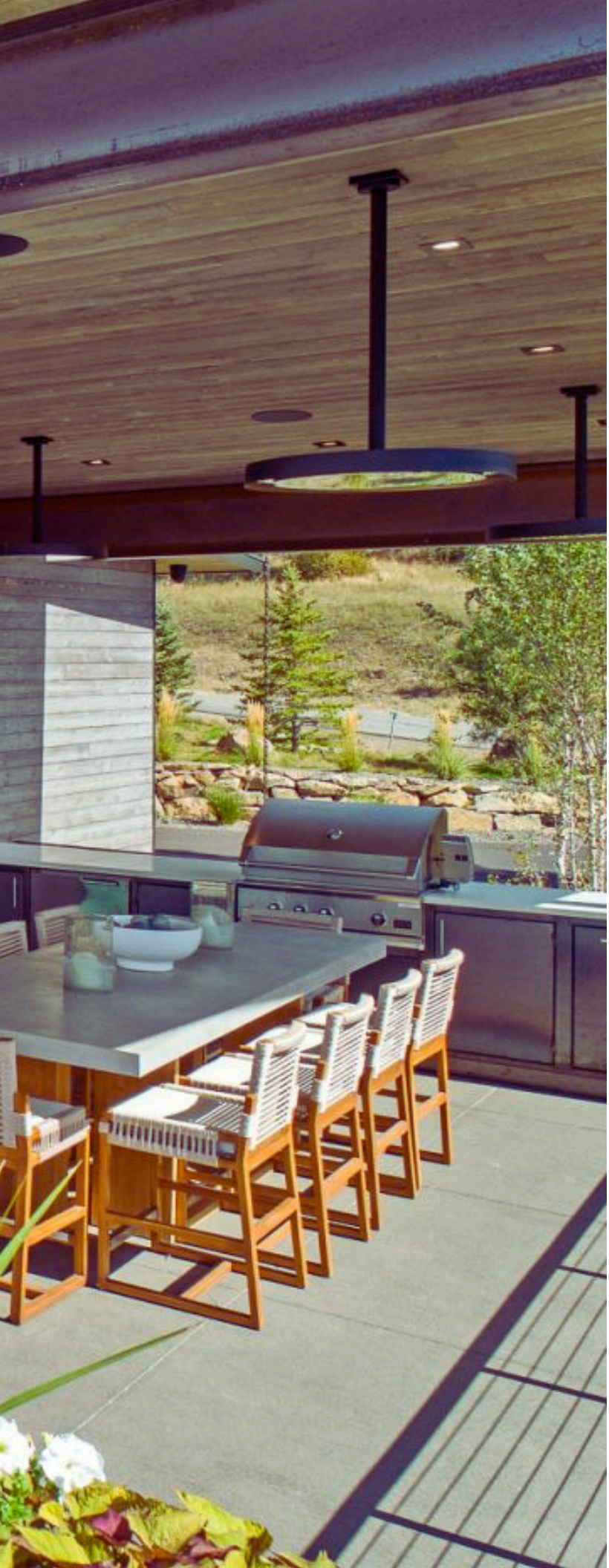
As urban densification reduces outdoor lot sizes, homeowners and designers are turning to smarter, more efficient strategies for outdoor living.

Smaller lots demand thoughtful zoning, multi-purpose spaces, and directional heating solutions, ensuring that every square foot is functional, comfortable, and visually appealing despite limited space.

- Outdoor spaces are designed to serve multiple functions within a smaller footprint
- Zoning is used to define dining, lounging, and gathering areas
- Integrated systems maximize usability without adding visual clutter

BROMIC INSIGHT
Radiant heating targets people rather than air, making it effective in compact outdoor spaces.





10

FROM OPTIONAL TO ESSENTIAL: OUTDOOR HEATING APPLIANCES

Power Planning

System Planning

Integration Systems

Outdoor heating appliances are increasingly transitioning from portable accessories to built-in infrastructure within modern homes.

This shift mirrors earlier trends in home design, where appliances evolved from optional add-ons to integrated features—such as built-in dishwashers in the 1970s, built-in kitchens in the 2000s, and built-in grills in the 2010s.

Now, in the 2020s, outdoor heating is following the same trajectory, becoming a standard element in outdoor living spaces.

Supporting this trend, infrared patio heaters have seen a **39%** increase in popularity among product categories, according to the *AIA Home Design Trends Survey.*

- Outdoor heating is specified as part of the design process—not added later
- Systems are planned alongside lighting, controls, and structure
- Heating is integrated to support consistent, reliable outdoor use

BROMIC INSIGHT

Design-led heating systems allow outdoor heat to be architecturally integrated from the begining.

PLAN FROM THE START TO ENJOY ALL SEASON LONG

Outdoor spaces are no longer optional—they are extensions of the home. Designing them for year-round use begins at the architectural stage, where key considerations like power, layout, mounting, and integration are addressed holistically.

When planned early, these elements work together, resulting in better performance, a more seamless design, and spaces that are consistently usable across seasons. When introduced later, they often become constraints that limit both effectiveness and aesthetics.

WHAT EARLY PLANNING ENABLES

- Proper electrical and gas capacity
- Seamless integration with lighting and controls
- More refined, cohesive architectural design
- Extended use across a wider range of conditions

For builders and architects, this represents an opportunity to elevate outdoor living into a fully realized system—one in which heating is considered alongside lighting, shade, and ventilation.

For homeowners, it means creating spaces that are not only visually appealing but consistently comfortable and usable throughout the year.

The most successful outdoor spaces are designed from the start—not added later.

